

20.4 KEY LANGUAGE UNLIKELY TO HAPPEN

If a future outcome is possible, but unlikely to happen, you can also use "what if" and "suppose" followed by the past tense to express it. You can also use "just in case" with the present tense.

The past tense shows the speaker thinks this is unlikely to happen.

Just imagine! What if we all passed our exams with perfect scores?



20.5 FURTHER EXAMPLES UNLIKELY TO HAPPEN

"Suppose" and "supposing" are interchangeable in this context.

Suppose I got caught cheating. My parents would be furious.

You should apply for a job just in case you fail your exams.

"Just" is added to "in case" to talk about preparation for a situation that is less likely.

The verb remains in the present tense after "just in case."



20.6 MARK WHETHER THE OUTCOMES ARE LIKELY OR UNLIKELY

I've studied hard. I'm buying champagne in case I pass all my exams.

Likely ☒ Unlikely ☐

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 What if she notices that I've copied the essay from the internet? | Likely ☐ Unlikely ☐ |
| 2 Suppose I won the lottery. I could afford to study abroad. | Likely ☐ Unlikely ☐ |
| 3 Suppose I write three good essays. That will be enough. | Likely ☐ Unlikely ☐ |
| 4 What if I studied for 14 hours every day from now on? | Likely ☐ Unlikely ☐ |
| 5 Suppose the examiner asks my name in French. What should I say? | Likely ☐ Unlikely ☐ |
| 6 I'm taking 10 pencils to the exam just in case mine break. | Likely ☐ Unlikely ☐ |
| 7 It's supposed to stop raining, but I'll bring an umbrella in case it doesn't. | Likely ☐ Unlikely ☐ |
| 8 What if I misunderstood all the questions? That would be a disaster. | Likely ☐ Unlikely ☐ |

